THE REAL PAWAR STRUGGLE

LOYALTIES IN THE FAMILY BASTION OF BARAMATI ARE DIVIDED AS THE FEUD BETWEEN SHARAD PAWAR AND NEPHEW AJIT SEES SUPRIYA SULE PITTED AGAINST SISTER-IN-LAW SUNETRA

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For the 6,200-odd voters of Katewadi, a village in the Baramati Lok Sabha constituency that goes to the polls on May 7, the decision on who to vote for is not incumbent on any discussion on the merits and demerits of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Congress. It is not even centered around Maharashtra's ruling Mahayuti (grand alliance) and the Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA). Rather it revolves around *saheb* (veteran politician Sharad Pawar) and *dada* (his nephew Ajit Pawar).

This is because the extended Pawar clan is from this place, located around 12 kilometres from Baramati town. The split in the Pawar *parivar*, and in the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) founded by the patriarch Sharad Pawar, when Ajit departed last year with a section of party MLAs to join hands with the Shiv Sena-BJP Mahayuti, is beginning to reflect in the fractured loyalties in Katewadi and Baramati. Katewadi thus has become the ground zero of the 'Pawar versus Pawar' battle and the division in the village is representative of the struggle for power and political supremacy between the NCP founder, and his recalcitrant nephew. Ajit now heads the NCP and is the deputy chief minister of Maharashtra; the Pawar senior-led NCP (Sharadchandra Pawar) party is fighting this election with the new 'man blowing a *tutari*' (blowing horn) symbol. And leading the respective charge for the two factions of the NCP in Katewadi and Baramati are *tai* Supriya Sule, Sharad Pawar's daughter, and *vahini* (Marathi for sister-in-law) Sunetra Pawar, Ajit's wife. The two Pawar women are pitted against each other in the seat, with Sule, a three-term MP from Baramati seeking to retain her position, the candidate for the NCP (SCP) and Sunetra the face of the NCP. The NCP (SCP) is part of the MVA and the Opposition INDIA bloc, and the NCP a constituent of the BJP-Shiv Sena Mahayuti in the state and of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) at the pan-India level. But though the contest may be between *tai* and *vahini*, the outcome of the Baramati battle will decide who will eventually claim the NCP legacy—*saheb* and *tai* or their challenger *dada*.

Meanwhile, Ajit's move to field his wife against his cousin, allegedly at the behest of the BJP, has reportedly not gone down well with most members of the Pawar family, leading them to close ranks behind the patriarch. The results are crucial for both sides. Ajit, whose chief ministerial ambitions are no secret, needs to prove to senior ally BJP that he can draw NCP voters to his bloc, the reason why the